The Secret

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CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 4 — THE SECRET

OPENING

Lights rise on a marketplace-adjacent work area.

SHIRA, TALIA, ADINA and DAFNA are occupied with ordinary tasks.

Possible activity

folding fabric;

sorting jewelry;

sewing;

arranging clothing;

preparing baskets;

threading beads;

organizing goods.

The scene should initially feel completely normal.

MARY enters.

She is trying to appear normal.

She is not succeeding.

Shira sees her first.

DAFNA

Mary!

Mary jumps. A small release of tension.

SHIRA, TALIA, ADINA, and DAFNA enter, carrying ordinary life with them: fabric, baskets, beads, clothing, market goods, or another established task from the Living Village.

ADINA

There you are.

TALIA

We have been looking everywhere.

DAFNA
Not everywhere.

TALIA
Enough places to justify saying everywhere.

Shira sees Mary clearly.

SHIRA
...Mary?

MARY
I'm here.

ADINA
We can see that.

DAFNA
Barely.

MARY
I'm fine.

Shira watches her. Mary tries to move with them.

ADINA
Good. Then come on.

Mary does not move.

ADINA
Mary.

MARY
I'm coming.

She still does not move.

TALIA
You said that without moving any part of your body.

DAFNA
Maybe she's practicing.

Mary tries to smile. Shira does not.

SHIRA
What happened?

MARY
Nothing.

Shira waits.

SHIRA
Mary.

Mary looks at the four women who have known her for years.

MARY
I need to tell you something.

THEY THINK THEY KNOW THE SECRET

The four women immediately become attentive in four different ways: Adina prepares to act, Talia studies Mary, Dafna anticipates a story, Shira watches Mary's face.

DAFNA
Joseph moved the wedding.

MARY
No.

TALIA
You and Joseph argued.

MARY
No.

DAFNA
Joseph said something foolish.

MARY
No.

TALIA
That remains statistically possible.

MARY
Talia.

ADINA
Is something wrong with the house?

MARY
No.

DAFNA
You're leaving Nazareth.

MARY
No.

Beat.

DAFNA
You kissed him.

Mary stares at her.

DAFNA
That was not a no.

SHIRA
Dafna.

DAFNA
OK! I'm Done.

Beat.

DAFNA
For now.

Mary almost smiles. Then Shira sees her face again. The humor disappears for Shira first.

SHIRA
Mary. What happened?

Mary takes a breath.

MARY
Something happened.

THE REVELATION

TALIA
What kind of something?

MARY
I don't know how to explain it.

TALIA
Start with what happened.

Mary looks at Talia.

MARY
That's the problem.

Silence.

MARY
Last night... I was alone.

She stops.

SHIRA
Take your time.

MARY
I don't think more time is going to make it sound any better.

DAFNA
That's not comforting.

Shira gives Dafna a look.

DAFNA
Sorry.

MARY
Someone came to me.

TALIA
Who?

MARY
A messenger.

ADINA
From whom?

Mary looks at them.

MARY
God.

Silence. No music. Let the word sit.

TALIA
A messenger from God.

MARY
Yes.

ADINA
Mary...

MARY
His name was Gabriel.

DAFNA
Gabriel WHO?

SHIRA
The Angel!..shhh...

MARY
He told me I had been chosen.

TALIA
Chosen for what?

Mary cannot soften it.

MARY
I'm going to have a child.

Silence.

DAFNA
Someday?

MARY
No.

Beat.

MARY
Now.

The four women absorb it.

ADINA
Does Joseph know?

MARY
No.

The room changes.

SHIRA
How?

Mary looks at her.

MARY
That's the part you're not going to believe.

MARY
Gabriel told me the child comes from God.

THE FIRST TEST OF THE TRUTH

Silence. Mary looks at the faces of four people who know her. Nobody has a prepared response.

TALIA
Mary...

MARY
I know.

TALIA
Listen to what you're asking us to believe.

MARY
I know.

TALIA
I'm not calling you a liar.

MARY
Then what are you saying?

TALIA
I'm saying I don't know how both things can be true.

Mary takes that in. It is painfully close to the questions she herself asked Gabriel.

MARY
Neither did I.

TALIA
What?

MARY
I asked him how.

Beat.

MARY
I asked why me. I asked what happens now.

TALIA
And?

MARY
I didn't get all the answers either.

TALIA
Then help me understand what you did get.

MARY
I can't. Not completely.

Talia wants another question. Mary sees it.

MARY
I know how it sounds.

TALIA
Then you understand why—

MARY
Yes!

The volume surprises everyone, including Mary.

MARY
Yes.

She steadies herself.

MARY
I don't understand exactly why.

Beat.

MARY
But, I still know what happened to me.

FOUR FRIENDS, FOUR RESPONSES

ADINA
When are you telling Joseph?

MARY
Today.

ADINA
Before anyone else knows.

MARY
Yes.

ADINA
Good.

SHIRA
Adina.

ADINA
I'm trying to help.

SHIRA
I know.

Dafna has been unusually quiet.

MARY
Dafna?

DAFNA
I'm trying very hard not to say the wrong thing.

A tiny breath of warmth.

MARY
How is that going?

DAFNA
Poorly.

Then Dafna becomes sincere.

DAFNA
I believe you.

Everyone looks at her.

DAFNA
I don't understand it.

Beat.

DAFNA
But I believe you. I'm still working on the rest.

Mary gives the smallest laugh through the tension.

Shira steps nearer, but does not crowd Mary.

SHIRA
Are you afraid?

MARY
Yes.

SHIRA
Then I'm staying.

Mary looks at her.

SHIRA
I can't promise you Joseph will understand.

Beat.

SHIRA
And I can't promise you he won't be hurt.

Beat.

SHIRA
But you're not walking to him alone.

THE SECRET LEAVES THE CIRCLE

The women continue speaking. Ordinary Nazareth traffic quietly resumes behind or around them. This is not a spy scene. People are simply living their lives.

TALIA
What are you going to tell him?

MARY
The truth.

TALIA
And if he doesn't believe it?

That lands.

MARY
Then I don't know what happens next.

Shira holds Mary's gaze.

SHIRA
You don't have to know how it ends tonight.

MARY
Apparently, nobody does.

A small, human release.

SHIRA
Then do the next thing.

MARY
Joseph.

SHIRA
Joseph.

MARY LOOKS AT SHIRA

MARY
Walk with me?

SHIRA
You don't even have to ask.

If physical contact is already consented and staged, Shira offers a hand. Mary chooses to take it.

They begin to move.

TALIA
Mary.

Mary turns.

TALIA
I still don't understand it. But I do know you… and I'm with you.

Mary nods.

ADINA
I'm with you too.

DAFNA
Well…Obviously.

TALIA
Nothing about you is obvious.

DAFNA
My loyalty is.

That lands more deeply than Dafna intended.

MARY
Thank you.

Mary and Shira start away.

ADINA
What exactly are you going to say?

Mary stops. For once, she has no answer.

Shira answers quietly.

SHIRA
Start with the truth.

Mary looks at Shira.

MARY
The truth… all right

Beat. exhale

Mary and Shira exit toward Joseph. Adina, Talia, and Dafna watch them go.

THE AUDIENCE KNOWS SOMETHING MARY DOESN'T

Do not follow Mary.

The PASSING VILLAGER reappears elsewhere in the living marketplace and crosses paths with another villager. Keep it small enough that Mary and her friends do not see or hear it.

GOSSIPER 4
Mary?

The first villager does not pretend to know the whole story.

GOSSIPER 2
That's what I heard.

They move on.

The line should echo the harmless information-transmission comedy of Scene 1, but the meaning has changed.

TRANSITION INTO SCENE 5

One beat of silence.

BANG!

A hammer strikes wood.

BANG!

Another.

BANG-BANG!

A completely different energy takes over. Lights shift sharply to Joseph's world.

JOSEPH is working, laughing, and completely unaware. LEVI, MALACHI, CALEB and EZRA are with him. The Scene 5 carpentry rhythm begins to emerge.

Mary is walking toward the most frightening conversation of her life.

Joseph is having a wonderful day.

He is building the future the audience now knows is about to be tested.

END SCENE 4.

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